

MAKING CHANGE HAPPEN

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Establish a sustained recovery free from abuse of all addictive behaviors.
2. Acquire the necessary skills to maintain long-term recovery from all addictive behaviors.
3. Strengthen motivation for change by identifying areas of life impacted by drug use and alternatives available in recovery.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE OPIOID DEPENDENCE

- A Working Recovery Plan
- Alternative Methods for Managing Pain
- Alternatives to Addictive Behavior
- Building My Support Network
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Personal Recovery Planning
- Problem Identification
- Relapse Prevention Planning
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Relapse Proneness
- Substance Abuse/Dependence

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Making Change Happen” exercise can be used with a client who is entering treatment for the first or fifth time. It can be used with clients in any stage of recovery when motivation wanes, self-doubt increases, or relapse indicators surface. Before assigning this exercise, it is helpful to educate

clients about the process of change and explain that the purpose of this activity is to help them see where they are in this process. Follow-up can include regular check-ins to track both progress and motivation, and to continue educating the client about the process of change.

MAKING CHANGE HAPPEN

Drug use and abuse can begin for one reason and continue for others. The same is true of other, more positive changes we decide to make in our lives—sometimes the reason or reasons we decide to enter treatment change along the way. People working to overcome addictions often go to professionals to find help and support for change. This exercise will help you to get a clearer picture of where you’ve been, where you are, and where you want to go, and to begin to see how to get there. After completing this exercise and following through by making some changes in your behavior, you and your therapist may find it useful to go on to the activity titled “A Working Recovery Plan,” which will help you continue defining how to get where you want to go.

1. Please identify the psychological factors that helped lead you to use opiate drugs (e.g., self-medication for physical or emotional pain, avoidance of problems, attempts to feel normal, pleasure-seeking).

2. Please use this space to list the social, cultural, and environmental reasons for your substance use (e.g., family norms, family history, availability of the drugs, acceptability of use among people close to you, use among your peer group).

3. Please describe the progression of your drug use from experimentation to opiate dependence. Are there other addictions that you need to address in treatment along with opiates?

4. Have you tried to quit opiates or gone into treatment before? _____ How many times? ____

What was the outcome each time? _____

What were the reasons you went back to using? _____

5. How have each of the following life areas been affected by your addiction to opiates?

a. Health: _____

b. Social: _____

c. Educational/career: _____

d. Legal: _____

e. Financial: _____

f. Relationships/family: _____

g. Spiritual: _____

h. Self-image and self-esteem: _____

i. Emotional: _____

6. As you think over your history, what factors do you think helped maintain your addiction?

7. What is your motivation for seeking treatment at this moment in time?

a. What increases your motivation? _____

b. What challenges it? _____

c. What fears do you have right now about your treatment and recovery?

8. If you've tried to quit before, either on your own or through treatment, what have you learned from those attempts that can be helpful to you in treatment this time?

-
9. A medical evaluation is a significant part of successful long-term healing and recovery from opiates and other substances. How will you find and work with a doctor and/or addictionologist for a complete physical and any necessary treatment and/or medications?

a. What questions do you want to have answered for you?

b. What fears might block you from following through with this?

-
10. For what other areas of your life do you need to include goals when you make a change plan (refer back to question 5)?

-
11. With your therapist, please identify a primary area of your life where you will begin working for change, and plan what behavioral steps you will take to address that area. Be sure to write about what factors will help increase your motivation and what potential barriers could decrease it.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy appointment, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.